

Chapter 35 - Disk and File I/O

Intuition Engine exposes one disk volume through a small MMIO block. BASIC uses the same block for LOAD, SAVE, BLOAD, and direct-mode DIR. Machine code can use the registers directly, but the examples here use BASIC POKE, POKE8, PEEK, and PEEK8 so they can be typed on the machine.

35.1 Names and Volume Rules

Every name in this chapter is relative to the IE disk volume. "GAME.BAS" names an entry at the root of the volume. "MUSIC/TITLE.MOD" names an entry in a volume subdirectory.

Names are rejected if they:

- begin with /
- contain . .

A rejected name sets FILE_STATUS to 1 and FILE_ERROR_CODE to 3 (FILE_ERR_PATH_TRAVERSAL). Reads are case-insensitive when an exact-case match is not present. Writes create or replace the named entry; they do not append.

35.2 Register Block

The block starts at \$F2200 and spans 32 bytes. Registers are 32-bit unless noted.

Address	Name	Access	Purpose
\$F2200	FILE_NAME_PTR	W	Pointer to a NUL-terminated name string
\$F2204	FILE_DATA_PTR	W	Pointer to the data buffer
\$F2208	FILE_DATA_LEN	W	Byte count for write; ignored by read
\$F220C	FILE_CTRL	W	Write 1 read, 2 write, 3 list
\$F2210	FILE_STATUS	R	0 OK, 1 error
\$F2214	FILE_RESULT_LEN	R	Bytes transferred by read or list
\$F2218	FILE_ERROR_CODE	R	Error code

FILE_CTRL fires the operation immediately. There is no busy bit and no interrupt. When the write to FILE_CTRL returns, the status registers already describe the result.

Operation codes:

Code	Name
1	FILE_OP_READ
2	FILE_OP_WRITE
3	FILE_OP_LIST

Error codes:

Code	Name	Meaning
0	FILE_ERR_OK	Success

Code	Name	Meaning
1	FILE_ERR_NOT_FOUND	Entry does not exist
2	FILE_ERR_PERMISSION	Operation was refused
3	FILE_ERR_PATH_TRAVERSAL	Name escaped the volume

35.3 Read

Set up a read like this:

1. Put a NUL-terminated name string in memory.
2. Write that address to FILE_NAME_PTR.
3. Write the destination buffer address to FILE_DATA_PTR.
4. Write 1 to FILE_CTRL.
5. Read FILE_STATUS.

If FILE_STATUS is 0, the file bytes are in the destination buffer and FILE_RESULT_LEN is the byte count. If status is 1, read FILE_ERROR_CODE.

The reader must provide enough destination memory. The disk block does not receive a destination capacity for reads. FILE_DATA_PTR may point anywhere in active RAM. If the destination begins near the end of the low memory slice and continues into backed extended RAM, the bytes are still copied as one ordinary RAM span, provided the whole span is inside active RAM.

FILE_DATA_LEN is write-side state. A read ignores it, even if it still contains the length from an earlier write. On a successful read, FILE_RESULT_LEN is the actual number of bytes copied. If the name is accepted but the read itself fails, FILE_RESULT_LEN is cleared to 0; use FILE_STATUS and FILE_ERROR_CODE as the final error test.

35.4 Write

Set up a write like this:

1. Put a NUL-terminated name string in memory.
2. Put the bytes to write in memory.
3. Write the name address to FILE_NAME_PTR.
4. Write the data address to FILE_DATA_PTR.
5. Write the byte count to FILE_DATA_LEN.
6. Write 2 to FILE_CTRL.
7. Read FILE_STATUS.

Writing creates the entry if it does not exist and replaces it if it does. The register block has no append mode.

35.5 List

Set up a directory listing like this:

1. Put a NUL-terminated directory name in memory. An empty string lists the root.
2. Write the name address to FILE_NAME_PTR.
3. Write a destination buffer address to FILE_DATA_PTR.
4. Write 3 to FILE_CTRL.

5. Read FILE_STATUS.

On success, the buffer receives sorted text with CR LF after each entry and a final NUL byte. Directory entries have a trailing /. FILE_RESULT_LEN counts the text bytes but not the final NUL.

35.6 BASIC Verbs

35.6.1 LOAD

```
LOAD "name"
```

LOAD reads a BASIC program from disk, tokenises it, makes it the current program, and clears variables. If the entry is not found, BASIC prints ?FILE NOT FOUND and keeps the previous program.

35.6.2 SAVE

```
SAVE "name"
```

SAVE writes the current BASIC program as detokenised numbered text. The saved text round-trips through LOAD.

35.6.3 BLOAD

```
BLOAD "name", addr
```

BLOAD reads raw bytes into memory at addr. It does not tokenise and it does not clear variables.

35.6.4 DIR

```
DIR  
DIR "subdir"
```

DIR is a direct-mode command. It lists the root or the named directory and prints entries separated by CR LF. Its output depends on the current disk volume, so it is shown here as a syntax template rather than a transcript with fixed expected output.

35.7 Typed MMIO Example

This BASIC listing writes two bytes to NOTE.TXT, clears the buffer, reads the file back, and prints the status and byte values.

```

10 REM NAME BUFFER AND DATA BUFFER
20 N=&H00720000:D=&H00720100
30 REM "NOTE.TXT",0
40 POKE8 N,78:POKE8 N+1,79:POKE8 N+2,84:POKE8 N+3,69
50 POKE8 N+4,46:POKE8 N+5,84:POKE8 N+6,88:POKE8 N+7,84
60 POKE8 N+8,0
70 REM FILE DATA "IE"
80 POKE8 D,73:POKE8 D+1,69
90 POKE &H000F2200,N
100 POKE &H000F2204,D
110 POKE &H000F2208,2
120 POKE &H000F220C,2
130 PRINT "WRITE ";PEEK(&H000F2210)
140 REM CLEAR THE BUFFER AND READ THE FILE BACK
150 POKE8 D,0:POKE8 D+1,0
160 POKE &H000F220C,1
170 PRINT "READ ";PEEK(&H000F2210)
180 PRINT "LEN ";PEEK(&H000F2214)
190 PRINT PEEK8(D);PEEK8(D+1)

```

Expected result:

```

WRITE 0
READ 0
LEN 2
73 69

```

Lines 40 to 60 build the byte string "NOTE.TXT",0. Lines 80 to 120 provide the two data bytes and fire the write operation. Line 150 clears the RAM buffer so the readback cannot be mistaken for leftover data. Lines 160 to 190 fire the read, print the byte count, and then print the two returned bytes.

35.8 Small-CPU Access

Full-address CPUs write the register block directly. The 6502 and Z80 use their documented MMIO translation apertures to reach the same block. The block also accepts byte-width writes: four writes to consecutive byte offsets compose a 32-bit register value in little-endian order.

Writing byte 0 of FILE_CTRL with 1, 2, or 3 triggers the matching operation. Writes to the upper bytes of FILE_CTRL do not trigger an operation.

35.9 Limits and Side Effects

Names longer than 255 bytes are truncated before lookup. Reads ignore FILE_DATA_LEN; writes use it as the number of bytes to copy from FILE_DATA_PTR. Successful reads and lists set FILE_RESULT_LEN to the number of bytes returned. Lists set FILE_RESULT_LEN to 0 on failure. Reads whose path is accepted but whose file cannot be read also set FILE_RESULT_LEN to 0. After a failed write, do not rely on FILE_RESULT_LEN.

Read destinations are ordinary bus addresses. They may be in low RAM or backed extended RAM, and the transfer may cross that boundary. The program must still choose an address range that is large enough for the file.

The block is synchronous and single-operation. Program code should not change FILE_NAME_PTR, FILE_DATA_PTR, or FILE_DATA_LEN while an operation is in progress, although in normal use there is no observable busy interval.